

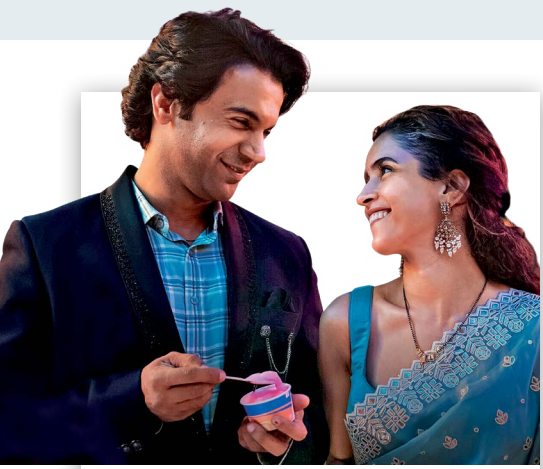
A TELLING MOMENT
Sheeba Chaddha (left) with Soni Razdan in the series *Bait*

CHADDHA ATTRIBUTES THE LUSH PATCH IN HER CAREER TO THE GROWING CLOUT OF STREAMING AS WELL AS TO THE "EXPANSION IN WRITING"

Along with features and web series, Chaddha also seeks collaborations with the talented gen-next of cinema through short films. In Aakash Chhabra's affecting Punjabi short, *Nighiyaan Chhavan*, Chaddha plays a mother who nurses a secret that subtly unravels during her son's visit. She recently won the Critics' Choice Award for Best Actress for her measured performance. "The script was gentle and inviting," she says. "One always wants to do shorts in which there's another lens or creating of a world."

Bait is the beginning of what's going to be a promising year in terms of releases. There's much-anticipated *Mirzapur: The Movie*; playing Manthara in Bollywood's most expensive film, *Ramayana*; and season two of web series *Bakaiti* from Pocket Aces. Chaddha is shooting two films and has a Netflix series going on the floors in April. She is hopeful that *Hamlet*, her other international project with Riz Ahmed, sees the light of day in India. Following its UK release, the drama is set for a US release soon. "To be offered the role of Gertrude and to receive so much trust, it makes one's heart melt," says Chaddha. "Gertrude is such a torn character... a person who wants to make choices for herself as a woman." For now, Chaddha seems to be making the right ones. ■

—Suhani Singh



▲ **APRIL 15** | *Netflix*

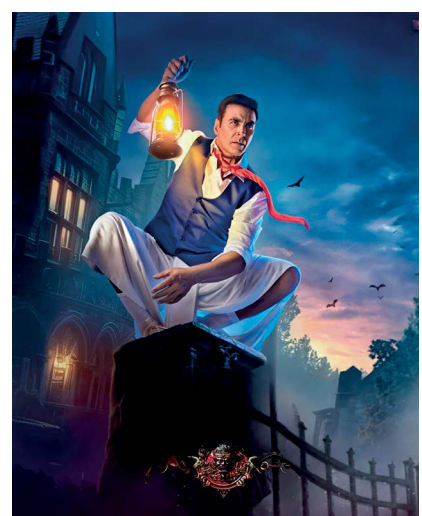
TOASTER

A most bizarre plot: Rajkummar Rao plays a stingy man with a habit of gifting toasters in weddings. When one such marriage falls apart, he becomes obsessed with getting the toaster back, convinced he has wasted his money. Sanya Malhotra plays his wife.

▼ **APRIL 17** | *Theatres*

Bhoot Bangla

Let nobody steal the OG's thunder. Before *Stree* made horror comedy Bollywood's most saleable genre, Akshay Kumar did it in 2007 with *Bhool Bhulaiya*. He teams up with its director Priyadarshan in this return to the genre, featuring Tabu.





▲ **APRIL 23** | *Theatres*

PATRIOT

Mahesh Narayanan, a stylish filmmaker, unites Mammootty and Mohanlal in a big-budget espionage thriller. The cast also includes Fahadh Faasil, Nayanthara and Revathy.

—Compiled by Devarsi Ghosh